



Douglas County Libraries

East of Eden  
by John Steinbeck

Look inside for  
Discussion Questions  
Author Interview/Biography  
Reviews

## Discussion Questions

1. Steinbeck has a character refer to Americans as a “breed,” and near the end of the book Lee says to a conflicted Cal that “We are all descended from the restless, the nervous, the criminals, the arguers and brawlers, but also the brave and independent and generous. If our ancestors had not been that, they would have stayed in their home plots in the other world and starved over the squeezed-out soil.” What makes this a quintessentially American book? Can you identify archotypically American qualities—perhaps some of those listed above—in the characters?
2. Sam Hamilton—called a “shining man”—and his children are an immigrant family in the classic American model. What comes with Sam and his wife Liza from the “old country”? How does living in America change them and their children? What opportunities does America provide for the clan, and what challenges?
3. Adam Trask struggles to overcome the actions of others—his father, brother, and wife—and make his own life. What is the lesson that he learns that frees him from Kate and allows him to love his sons? He says to Cal near the end that “if you want to give me a present—give me a good life. That would be something I could value.” Does Adam have a good life? What hinders him? Would you characterize his life as successful in the end?
4. Lee is one of the most remarkable characters in American literature, a philosopher trapped by the racial expectations of his time. He is the essence of compassion, erudition, and calm, serving the Trasks while retaining a complex interior and emotional life. Do you understand why he speaks in pidgin, as he explains it to Sam Hamilton? How does his character change—in dress, speech, and action—over the course of the book? And why do you think Lee stays with the Trasks, instead of living on his own in San Francisco and pursuing his dream?
5. Women in the novel are not always as fully realized as the main male characters. The great exception is Adam Trask’s wife, Cathy, later Kate the brothel owner. Clearly Kate’s evil is meant to be of biblical proportions. Can you understand what motivates her? Is she truly evil or does Steinbeck allow some traces of humanity in his characterization of her? What does her final act, for Aron Trask, indicate about her (well-hidden) emotions?
6. Sibling rivalry is a crushing reoccurrence in *East of Eden*. First Adam and his brother Charles, then Adam’s sons Cal and Aron, act out a drama of jealousy and competition that seems fated: Lee calls the story of Cain and Abel the “symbol story of the human soul.” Why do you think this is so, or do you disagree? Have you ever experienced or witnessed such a rivalry? Do all of the siblings in the book act out this drama or do some escape it? If so, how? If all of the “C” characters seem initially to embody evil and all the “A” characters good—in this novel that charts the course of good and evil in human experience—is it true that good and evil are truly separate? Are the C characters also good, the A characters capable of evil?
7. Abra, at first simply an object of sexual competition to Cal and Aron, becomes a more complex character in her relationships with the brothers but also with Lee and her own family. She rebels against Aron’s insistence that she be a one-dimensional symbol of pure femininity. What is it that she’s really looking for? Compare her to some of the other women in the book (Kate, Liza, Adam’s stepmother) and try to identify some of the qualities that set her apart. Do you think she might embody the kind of “modern” woman that emerged in postwar America?

8. Some of Steinbeck's ethnic and racial characterizations are loaded with stereotype. Yet he also makes extremely prescient comments about the role that many races played in the building of America, and he takes the time to give dignity to all types of persons. Lee is one example of a character that constantly subverts expectations. Can you think of other scenes or characters that might have challenged conventional notions in Steinbeck's time? In ours? How unusual do you think it might have been to write about America as a multicultural haven in the 1950s? And do you agree that that is what Steinbeck does, or do you think he reveals a darker side to American diversity?

9. What constitutes true wealth in the book? The Hamiltons and the Trasks are most explicitly differentiated by their relationship to money: though Sam Hamilton works hard he accumulates little, while Adam Trask moons and mourns and lives off the money acquired by his father. Think of different times that money is sought after or rejected by characters (such as Will Hamilton and Cal Trask) and the role that it plays to help and hinder them in realizing their dreams. Does the quest for money ever obscure deeper desires?

10. During the naming of the twins, Lee, Sam, and Adam have a long conversation about a sentence from Genesis, disagreeing over whether God has said an act is ordered or predetermined. Lee continues to think about this conversation and enlists the help of a group of Chinese philosophers to come to a conclusion: that God has given humans choice by saying that they may (the Hebrew word for "may," *timshel*, becomes a key trope in the novel), that people can choose for themselves. What is Steinbeck trying to say about guilt and forgiveness? About family inheritance versus free will? Think of instances where this distinction is important in the novel, and in your own life.

11. The end of the novel and the future of the Trasks seems to rest with Cal, the son least liked and least understood by his father and the town. What does Cal come to understand about his relationship to his past and to each member of his family? The last scene between Adam and Cal is momentous; what exactly happens between them, and how hopeful a note is this profound ending? Why is Lee trying to force Cal to overturn the assumption that lives are "all inherited"? What do you think Cal's future will be?

12. *East of Eden* is a combination novel/memoir; Steinbeck writes himself in as a minor character in the book, a member of the Hamilton family. What do you think he gained by morphing genres in this fashion? What distinguishes this from a typical autobiography? What do you think Steinbeck's extremely personal relationship to the material contributes to the novel?

## Author Interview

### Talk With John Steinbeck

by Lewis Nichols

Sept. 28, 1952

LIKE many another man, outwardly upstanding, John Steinbeck carries around with him a wide streak of self-confessed madness. In his case, this takes the form of wanting to write plays. Since his normal trade is that of being a serious novelist, it is only natural that the plays to which he aspires would be comedies. This is inevitable, of course. Whether or not it is Hamlet wanting to be the first gravedigger, Mr. Steinbeck makes no secret of his ambition, although to date his wooing of the theatre has been an oddly one-sided affair. He will fix that up some time. Or else.

This ambition, and certain other matters, Mr. Steinbeck explained the other day, as "East of Eden" went into the bookstores. The other matters ranged casually from formal research to an informal exposition of what a well-trained myna bird should say. Of his latest novel there was little, for Mr. Steinbeck is not one to gravely review his work when there is anything else at hand. The word Art and its use of the upper case would send him shuddering from the room. He is a story teller with an antic imagination, and together with his friend and editor, Pascal Covici, as straight man - he probably would not disgrace the Palace. An amiable man, he can eye his own personal devil with amused detachment.

"I'm just determined I'm going to learn something about the theatre," he said. "Last time out we were kicked around like dogs ('Burning Bright', fifteen performances) but I still want to do it. This shows a truly pure quality of stupidity. Just nuts. I'm so fascinated by everything about the theatre, I don't really care if the show's a flop."

NOW that "East of Eden" is out of his hands, Mr. Steinbeck will be free to resume his interrupted courtship. He and Elia Kazan presently will turn the novel into a script suitable for the screen, which is, after all, a form of the theatre, if not the one to which Mr. Steinbeck currently aspires. More like it is talk of a Steinbeck-Frank Loesser collaboration on a musical version of "Cannery Row." This is just talk so far, no more, but Mr. Steinbeck is eager. Anything to do with the theatre will find him running, like a fire buff after the engine.

But what about "East of Eden"? Was there nothing to say? Yes: The research had been agreeable.

"I went back through old Salinas (Calif.) newspapers," he began. "Wonderful things, those papers. Social notes, church notes, births, deaths. I finally got to the Boer War and found myself wondering who'd win." He stopped, then added moodily, "No matter how much checking you do, somebody's going to squawk about a mistake. And be right, too, likely."

"I saw some of the old timers. One of them bothered me. He said the thing he remembered about me was that one cold day I was walking along the street with my coat tied together with a horse blanket pin. That never happened. That was just making a good story. We weren't poor. Before being middle class became a phobia, we were proud of being it."

LATELY returned from Europe, Mr. Steinbeck had in London a triumph he clearly regards in much the same light as a far lesser man would regard the Pulitzer Prize - he was invited to inspect the plumbing at Buckingham Palace. This came about through his indulgence in a passion which is almost as strong as that for the theatre, a love of hardware stores. About this, there is some dispute. Mr. Steinbeck says he buys in hardware stores only those things he will actually use "mostly"; Mr. Covici says, reprovingly, that he buys gadgets. At any event, a day after Mr. Steinbeck had indulged his craving during a long tour of British hardware, the ironworkers' guild telephoned and formally invited him on a tour below stairs at Buckingham. He will regret forever that he was unable to accept.

He now lives officially in New York, owning a house with a garden ("Just keep away from white flowers and a New York garden's easy") and a third floor room of his own. This, he says, is the first room of his own he ever has had. Machinery of one sort or another crowds all but one small corner, where is placed the hot seat for literary endeavor. Sawdust from woodworking instruments lies thick on the floor, and when the master is in residence, a glum sign on the door proclaims, "Buzzard's Despair." When he goes out, he meets on his return the reverse of the sign, "Tidy Town," which shows that women have got in and tidied up the place.

It is a very quiet room. For companionship, Mr. Steinbeck would like to get a myna bird. With a tape recorder he would teach this to ask questions, never answer, just ask. "Is that your wife with you?" "What are you doing here?" \*Not looking so well today, are you, old man?" A quiet room where nothing ever happens.

## Author Biography

John Steinbeck was an American novelist who is known for works such as the Pulitzer Prize-winning novel, 'The Grapes of Wrath,' as well as 'Of Mice and Men' and 'East of Eden.'

by Biography.com Editors Updated: Apr 14, 2021

### Who Was John Steinbeck?

John Steinbeck was a Nobel and Pulitzer Prize-winning American novelist and the author of *Of Mice and Men*, *The Grapes of Wrath* and *East of Eden*. Steinbeck dropped out of college and worked as a manual laborer before achieving success as a writer. His works often dealt with social and economic issues. His 1939 novel, *The Grapes of Wrath*, about the migration of a family from the Oklahoma Dust Bowl to California, won a Pulitzer Prize and a National Book Award. Steinbeck served as a war correspondent during World War II, and he was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1962.

### Early Life and Education

John Ernst Steinbeck Jr. was born on February 27, 1902, in Salinas, California. Steinbeck was raised with modest means. His father, John Ernst Steinbeck, tried his hand at several different jobs to keep his family fed: He owned a feed-and-grain store, managed a flour plant and served as treasurer of Monterey County. His mother, Olive Hamilton Steinbeck, was a former schoolteacher.

For the most part, Steinbeck — who grew up with three sisters — had a happy childhood. He was shy but smart. He formed an early appreciation for the land and in particular California's Salinas Valley, which would greatly inform his later writing. According to accounts, Steinbeck decided to become a writer at the age of 14, often locking himself in his bedroom to write poems and stories.

In 1919, Steinbeck enrolled at Stanford University — a decision that had more to do with pleasing his parents than anything else — but the budding writer would prove to have little use for college.

Over the next six years, Steinbeck drifted in and out of school, eventually dropping out for good in 1925, without a degree.

Following Stanford, Steinbeck tried to make a go of it as a freelance writer. He briefly moved to New York City, where he found work as a construction worker and a newspaper reporter, but then returned to California, where he took a job as a caretaker in Lake Tahoe and began his writing career.

### John Steinbeck's Books

Steinbeck wrote 31 books over the course of his career. His most well-known novels include *Of Mice and Men* (1937), *Grapes of Wrath* (1939), and *East of Eden* (1952).

'Of Mice and Men' (1937) Two poor migrant workers, George and Lennie, are working for the American dream in California during the Great Depression. Lennie, who has a mild mental disability, is steadfastly faithful to his friend George, but he has a habit of getting into trouble. Their goal: to own an acre of land and a shack. After they both secure jobs working the fields of the Salinas Valley — Steinbeck's own hometown — their dream seems more attainable than ever. However, Lennie's inclinations eventually get him into trouble again, spiraling to a tragic conclusion for both men. The book was later transformed into a Broadway play and three movies.

'The Grapes of Wrath' (1939) Widely considered Steinbeck's finest and most ambitious novel, this book tells the story of a dispossessed Oklahoma family and their struggle to carve out a new life in California at the height of the Great Depression, the book captured the mood and angst of the nation during this time period. At the height of its popularity, *The Grapes of Wrath* sold 10,000 copies per week.

'The Pearl' (1947) This story, based on a Mexican folktale, explores human nature and the potential of love. Kino, a poor diver who gathers pearls from the ocean floor, lives with his wife Juana and their infant son Coyotito by the sea. On the same day Coyotito is stung by a scorpion and is turned away by the town doctor because they can't afford care, Kino finds the largest pearl he's ever seen on one of his dives. The pearl, which brings the potential of great fortune, ignites the neighbors' jealousy, eventually becoming a dangerous agent of evil.

'East of Eden' (1952) Once again set in Steinbeck's hometown of Salinas, California, this story follows the intersecting stories of two farming families, the Trasks and the Hamiltons, from the Civil War to World War I, as their lives reenact the fall of Adam and Eve and the rivalry of Cain and Abel. The book was later adapted into a 1955 film directed by Elia Kazan and starring James Dean in his first major movie role. Dean was later nominated for an Academy Award for his performance, which he received posthumously.

Some of Steinbeck's other works include *Cup of Gold* (1929), *The Pastures of Heaven* (1932) and *To a God Unknown* (1933), all of which received tepid reviews. It wasn't until *Tortilla Flat* (1935), a humorous novel about paisano life in the Monterey region was released, that the writer achieved real success.

Steinbeck struck a more serious tone with *In Dubious Battle* (1936) and *The Long Valley* (1938), a collection of short stories. He continued to write in his later years, with credits including *Cannery Row* (1945), *Burning Bright* (1950), *The Winter of Our Discontent* (1961) and *Travels with Charley: In Search of America* (1962).

## **Awards**

In 1940, Steinbeck earned a Pulitzer Prize for *The Grapes of Wrath*. In 1962, the author received the Nobel Prize for Literature — "for his realistic and imaginative writings, combining as they do sympathetic humor and keen social perception." Upon receiving the award, Steinbeck said the writer's duty was "dredging up to the light our dark and dangerous dreams for the purpose of improvement."

## **Later Life**

During World War II, Steinbeck served as a war correspondent for the New York Herald Tribune.

Around this same time, he traveled to Mexico to collect marine life with friend Edward F. Ricketts, a marine biologist. Their collaboration resulted in the book *Sea of Cortez* (1941), which describes marine life in the Gulf of California.

## **Wives and Children**

Steinbeck was married three times and had two sons. In 1930, Steinbeck met and married his first wife, Carol Henning. Over the following decade, he poured himself into his writing with Carol's support and paycheck, until the couple divorced in 1942.

Steinbeck was married to his second wife, Gwyndolyn Conger, from 1943 to 1948. The couple had two sons together, Thomas (born 1944) and John (born 1946). In 1950, Steinbeck wed his third wife, Elaine Anderson Scott. The couple remained together until his death in 1968.

## **Death**

Steinbeck died of heart disease on December 20, 1968, at his home in New York City.

## Reviews

You would think that by now I would be a good judge of which books I would be likely to enjoy or not enjoy, wouldn't you? Well, apparently not. *East of Eden* has been on my Classics Club list for years now and I've been resisting reading it for all this time, convinced that I wouldn't like it. I'm not sure why I felt that way – maybe because I have memories of reading Steinbeck's novella *The Pearl* at school and being unimpressed. Anyway, none of that matters now, because I have finally read *East of Eden* and loved it!

The novel opens with a description of the Salinas Valley in California. Right from the beginning, I knew I was going to like Steinbeck's writing in this book.

*The Salinas was only a part-time river. The summer sun drove it underground. It was not a fine river at all, but it was the only one we had and so we boasted about it—how dangerous it was in a wet winter and how dry it was in a dry summer. You can boast about anything if it's all you have. Maybe the less you have, the more you are required to boast.*

Samuel Hamilton, the grandfather of the narrator (whom we can assume to be Steinbeck himself), is an Irish immigrant who settles in the valley with his wife, Liza, and their nine children towards the end of the 19th century. Over the course of the novel we get to know the various members of the Hamilton family – some better than others – but of much more interest to me was the story of another family: the Trasks.

Originally from New England, Adam Trask was once nearly killed by his jealous half-brother, Charles, who believed that their father loved Adam more. With the Biblical title of the book (inspired by the line from Genesis: "And Cain went out from the presence of the Lord, and dwelt in the Land of Nod, on the east of Eden") it's easy to equate the characters of Charles and Adam with Cain and Abel, especially as they begin with the same letters.

Although the brothers have since been reconciled, when Adam marries he and his new wife, Cathy, move to the Salinas Valley, leaving Charles behind to take care of the family farm. It is here in California that Cathy gives birth to twins Aron and Cal (A and C again) and history seems to be about to repeat itself.

The characters in *East of Eden* range from the very good – such as Adam and Aron – to the completely evil, like Cathy:

*There was a time when a girl like Cathy would have been called possessed by the devil. She would have been exorcised to cast out the evil spirit, and if after many trials that did not work, she would have been burned as a witch for the good of the community. The one thing that may not be forgiven a witch is her ability to distress people, to make them restless and uneasy and even envious.*

Between the two extremes, there are characters like Cal, whose natures are more nuanced and ambiguous. The idea at the heart of the novel is that there is the potential for both good and evil in each of us and that it's up to the individual person to choose what they want to be:

*"But the Hebrew word, the word timshel—'Thou mayest'— that gives a choice. It might be the most important word in the world. That says the way is open. That throws it right back on a man. For if 'Thou mayest'—it is also true that 'Thou mayest not.'"*

Like Charles before him, Cal desperately wants some love and attention from his father and is envious of his brother Aron, but being a complex human being, we see him struggling against temptation and trying to do what he knows is right, sometimes successfully and sometimes not.

My favourite character, though, is definitely Lee, Adam's Chinese servant: he's so wise, so loyal, so patient and uncomplaining. Over the course of the novel he becomes much more than just a servant to the Trask family, helping to raise the children, providing valuable insights and offering advice and friendship.

I found *East of Eden* a surprisingly compelling read; I honestly hadn't expected to love it as much as I did or to find myself wanting to turn the pages so quickly. I now feel much more enthusiastic about reading more Steinbeck – not immediately, but soon.

## Read-Alikes

Absalom, Absalom! by William Faulkner

The story of Thomas Sutpen, an enigmatic stranger who came to Jefferson in the early 1830s to wrest his mansion out of the muddy bottoms of the north Mississippi wilderness. He was a man, Faulkner said, "who wanted sons and the sons destroyed him."

The Brothers Karamazov by Fyodor Dostoyevsky

Driven by intense, uncontrollable emotions of rage and revenge, the four Karamazov brothers all become involved in the brutal murder of their despicable father.

The House of the Spirits by Isabel Allende

The Trueba family embodies strong feelings from the beginning of the 20th century through the assassination of Allende in 1973.